# MOUSE -- Interview Prep

## Derek Schmelyun

April 06, 2026

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### STORY ARC

Derek Schmelyun followed his state-champion brother Rickey into McCollum's program, earning bronze at PIAA states as a junior at 135 lbs and District 3 gold as a senior at 140 -- wearing a throwback singlet from 30 years ago that McCollum was 'totally against' until they proved themselves. His four-year training partnership with Devin O'Brien defined his career. He chose Kutztown D-II over Bloomsburg D-I, where coach Bellanca said he'd 'perfected what he's good at' and was 'very difficult to point.'

### QUESTIONS

**1. Your brother Rickey won a state championship in 2006. What was it like growing up in that shadow, and did it drive you or weigh on you?**

*Rickey was a state champ at Bermudian -- Derek followed him through the same program. Sibling tension produces great sound bites.*

**2. Rickey wanted you to go D-I at Bloomsburg. You chose Kutztown D-II instead. How did that conversation go?**

*From 2009 article -- Derek said 'at college I want to enjoy myself.' Choosing his own path says something about who he is beyond the mat.*

**3. What was Coach McCollum's wrestling room like? What would someone see if they walked in during a Tuesday practice?**

*Standard MOUSE question -- the room is the documentary's central location. Every wrestler paints it differently.*

**4. McCollum was 'totally against' you and Devin wearing the throwback singlets at districts. How did you convince him, and what did it mean when he said 'if you're going to do it, you're going to have to do something special'?**

*From 2009 district article -- both wore 30-year-old singlet designs and both won gold. McCollum challenged them to earn it. Perfect McCollum moment.*

**5. You and Devin O'Brien trained together for four years -- seasons, sectionals, districts, regionals, states. The paper said 'there's not much one does and the other does not.' What made that partnership work?**

*The bond between training partners is a wrestling-specific relationship. Could be a powerful thread in the doc.*

**6. You earned bronze at states as a junior, then won districts as a senior. When you were out on the mat at Giant Center, were you wrestling for yourself, for McCollum, for Bermudian -- who were you wrestling for?**

*From 2008 and 2009 state tournament articles. Gets at motivation and belonging -- the documentary's core theme.*

**7. Your coach Bellanca at Kutztown said you'd 'perfected what you're good at' and you were 'very difficult to point.' Where did that come from -- was that McCollum's influence, or something else?**

*Ties college success back to the Bermudian program. Bellanca's quote is a strong setup -- Derek's answer connects the dots.*

**8. If you could put into words what the Bermudian Springs wrestling program gave you that you couldn't have gotten anywhere else -- what would that be?**

*The big closer. Open-ended enough for a genuine moment, specific enough to stay on-theme.*

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### SOURCE ARTICLES

2005-12-08 -- Boiling Springs Edges Bermudian Springs in Wrestling Match
2008-01-14 -- Eagles Overwhelm Delone Catholic in Dominant Victory
2008-03-09 -- Bermudian Springs Wrestlers Shine at State Tournament
2009-01-07 -- Bermudian Springs Wrestler Excels at D-II Level

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2009-02-08 -- Schuylkill Valley Falls Short in PIAA Team Tournament
2009-02-22 -- Bermudian Springs Wrestlers Win Golds, Honoring 30-Year Singlet Tradition
2009-03-06 -- Mental Toughness and Grit Shine at State Wrestling Championships